

how to go forward. And when we go forward, we need to know how to keep the ball,” a weary Udita explained to *Sportstar* after the demanding training run.

The women’s national team is in transition. Four years ago, it was celebrating a historic fourth-place finish at the Tokyo Olympics. Today, it is reeling from relegation in the 2024-25 FIH Pro League and the failure to qualify for Paris 2024. The mood has dipped, and before turning attention to the Asia Cup in China — with a World Cup berth at stake — the side has had to confront its shortcomings.

Coming to terms

At 19, Salima Tete played in the Tokyo bronze-medal playoff against Great Britain. Now 23 and captain, she is expected to steady the group after a disastrous campaign. Yet Salima insists the leadership load is shared.

“There are a lot of seniors in the

dressing room, like Savita [Punia] di. It’s not like I’m the captain and only I’ll have to speak when it’s needed. We keep discussing and exchanging notes on where we can improve in a match, especially at half-time. If I make a mistake, they come and give me feedback.”

Savita Punia, once a wide-eyed debutant 16 years ago, is now the team’s anchor in turbulent times.

“When everything’s rosy, everyone will feel good. When Tokyo happened, we didn’t have to motivate anyone because we were getting a lot of love from outside. Then, we didn’t qualify for the Olympics. There was a very short turnaround time and then the Pro League. I was the captain then, and as a senior, you have to keep your emotions aside and support the



India’s Asia Cup record

Titles: 2 (2004, 2017)

Runner-up: 2 (1999, 2009)

Third place: 3 (1993, 2013, 2022)

India has won 26 out of 47 matches in the Asia Cup.

Groups

Pool A

China
South Korea
Malaysia
Chinese Taipei

Pool B

India
Japan
Thailand
Singapore

